QA Salary Guide 2026

What Software Testers Really Earn (And How to Reach the Next Salary Band)



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Real salary bands across the UK, USA and India—plus the three skills that consistently increase earning potential.

Based on 25+ years of hiring QA professionals.

Introduction Guide 2026

If you're reading this, you're probably wondering one of three things:

- Am I underpaid?
- What should I actually be earning?
- How do I move into the next salary bracket?

After more than twenty-five years interviewing and hiring software testers, I've seen the same mistake repeatedly.

People focus on experience.

Companies pay for value.

This guide explains the salary bands I This guide explains the salary bands I repeatedly see across today's QA market and, more importantly, what moves people from one band to the next.



Fee years of professionals.

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QA Salary Bands: A Global View

Junior / Graduate

£25K-£35K | $45K-£60K | ₹3L-₹6L

Mid-Level

£35K-£55K | $60K-£90K | ₹6L-₹12L

Senior

£55K-£85K | $90K-£130K | ₹12L-₹25L

Lead / Manager

£85K-£120K+ | $130K-₹190K+ | ₹25L-₹50L+



All figures are approximate averages. Location within country and specific skills affect actual compensation.

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Junior / Graduate QA: Building the Foundation

Typical Responsibilities

- Writing test cases
- Logging defects
- Learning Agile
- Supporting senior testers

Focus on Learning—Not Salary

One year in a great engineering culture can be worth three years somewhere else.

Biggest Mistake

Choosing the highest paying job instead of the highest learning opportunity.



Culture is your multiplier. Prioritize growth.

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Mid-Level QA: Bridging the Gap

Key Responsibilities

- API testing
- Regression strategy
- Risk assessment
- Automation exposure
- Independent delivery

Where the Gap Lies

This is where I see people leave the most money on the table. The difference between £35k and £50k is rarely years of experience. It's positioning.

The Path Forward

Translate your technical skills into business value. Position yourself as a problem solver, not just a ticket closer.



Know your worth. Position for value.

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Senior QA: Strategic Impact

Key Responsibilities

- Automation leadership
- Mentoring
- Test strategy
- Quality coaching
- Cross-team influence

The True Differentiator

Communication. Technical skill gets interviews. Business communication gets promotions.

The Senior Mindset

Translate complex technical concepts into business value. Influence stakeholders at all levels.



Communicate to lead. Influence to grow.

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Lead / Principal QA: Executive Leadership

Key Responsibilities

- Hiring & Talent Development
- Budget Management
- Quality Strategy & Governance
- CTO & Board Engagement
- Commercial Decision-Making

What Fundamentally Changes

Testing knowledge is assumed. Leadership becomes your product. You are now judged on team output and business impact, not individual contribution.

The Executive Mandate

Build scalable, high-performing teams. Drive business strategy through quality. Own the commercial outcomes of your decisions.



Lead by influence. Deliver by strategy.

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The Three Salary Multipliers: Accelerating Your QA Career

1 Automation Judgment



Not Learn Playwright.

Know What When Why

to automate.

Average uplift
+£10-15k

2 Domain Expertise



Become known for

FinTech

Healthcare

Gaming

Retail

Insurance

Payments

Average uplift
+£10-20k

3 Communication



Bug reports

Stakeholder management

Presentation

Risk communication

Leadership

Average uplift
+£10k+



Multiply your value. Grow your impact.

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Mastering Salary Negotiation: From Emotion to Evidence

Never Say

"I'd like more money."

Instead

Based on current market data and my automation experience, I'm seeing comparable positions between **£X and £Y**. I'd like to be somewhere within that range.

from emotion... ▶ ...to evidence.

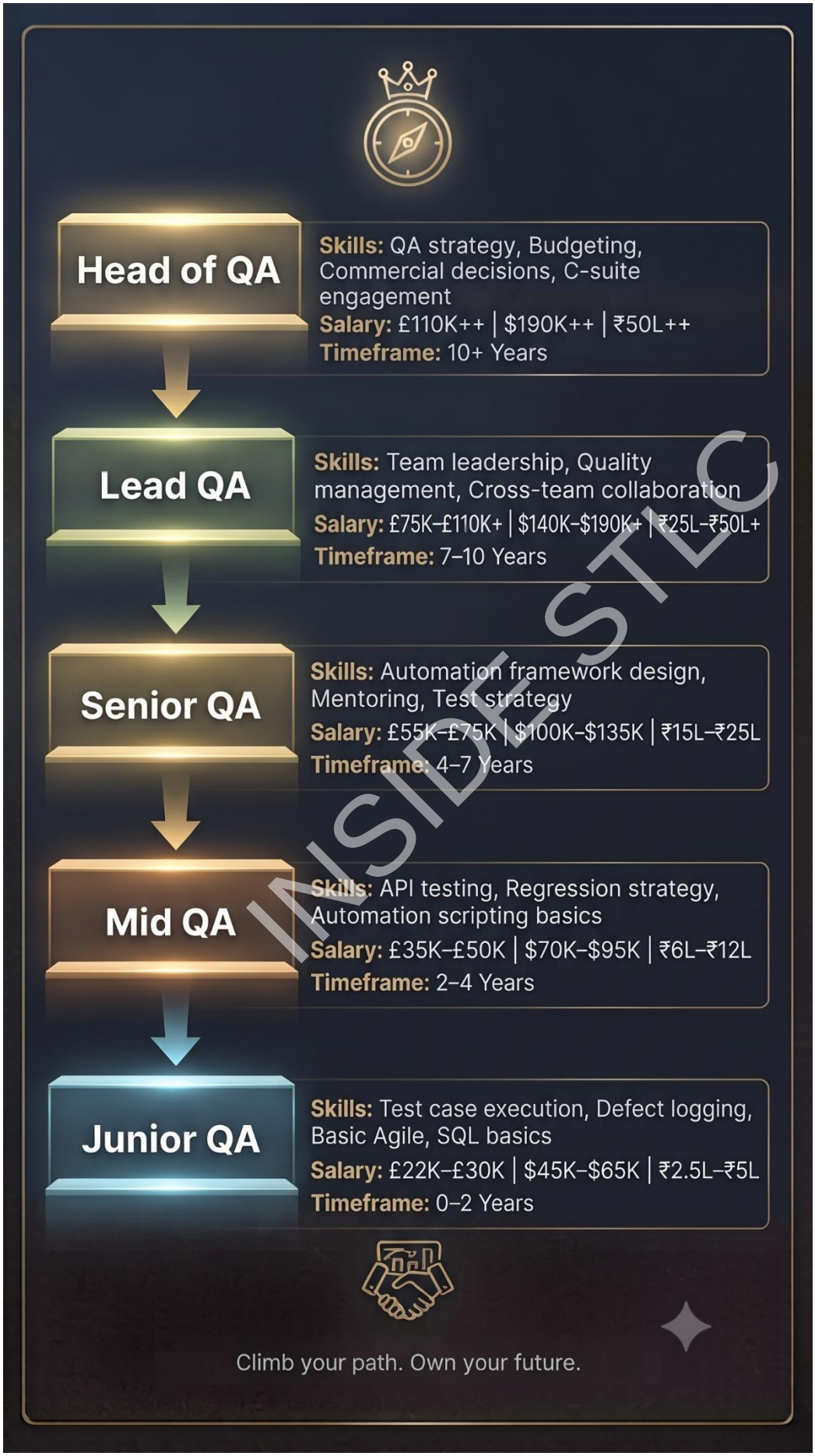
Negotiation Checklist

- ☐ Research salaries
- ☐ Benchmark yourself
- ☐ Prepare examples
- ☐ Know your minimum
- ☐ Ask about bonuses
- ☐ Ask about training
- ☐ Ask about pension
- ☐ Ask about shares



Negotiate with confidence. Position for value.

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Head of QA
Skills: QA strategy, Budgeting, Commercial decisions, C-suite engagement
Salary: £110K++ | $190K++ | ₹50L++
Timeframe: 10+ Years
Lead QA
Skills: Team leadership, Quality management, Cross-team collaboration
Salary: £75K–£110K+ | $140K–$190K+ | ₹25L–₹50L+
Timeframe: 7–10 Years
Senior QA
Skills: Automation framework design, Mentoring, Test strategy
Salary: £55K–£75K | $100K–$135K | ₹15L–₹25L
Timeframe: 4–7 Years
Mid QA
Skills: API testing, Regression strategy, Automation scripting basics
Salary: £35K–£50K | $70K–$95K | ₹6L–₹12L
Timeframe: 2–4 Years
Junior QA
Skills: Test case execution, Defect logging, Basic Agile, SQL basics
Salary: £22K–£30K | $45K–$65K | ₹2.5L–₹5L
Timeframe: 0–2 Years
Climb your path. Own your future.
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What's Next?
Accelerate Your QA Career

High-Demand Skills to Increase Your Salary (Next 12 Months)

- API Testing
- SQL
- Playwright
- Automation Strategy
- AI-assisted Testing
- AI-assisted Testing
- Domain Expertise
- Communication

Continue Learning Path

Invest in these high-ROI skills to unlock the next salary band. Continuous learning is your competitive advantage.

Resources & Community

Free Resources
www.insidestlc.com/resources

Inside STLC Academy
www.insidestlcacademy.com

YouTube Channel
Inside STLC



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